

Dangers of Change Approval Processes

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Change approval processes are designed to protect organizations. In IT and DevOps environments especially, they help make sure that changes to software, infrastructure, or systems are properly authorized, documented, tested, and implemented. According to Linford & Company LLP, the goal of IT change management is to make sure all changes are authorized, tracked, tested, and aligned with service commitments and system requirements. However, when approval processes become rigid, outdated, or overly bureaucratic, they can actually create serious risks.

Approval management itself is the systematic process of seeking and granting authorization for tasks such as documentation, purchases, or strategic decisions. Modern systems often include automated workflows, audit trails, mobile accessibility, and tracking features. As explained by CMW Lab, these systems aim to reduce human error, increase transparency, and eliminate ambiguity about what leadership has approved. When done correctly, approval workflows can protect organizations from compliance issues, delays, and reputational harm.

The danger begins when approval processes become slow and inflexible. One major problem is time wastage. Manual approval chains that require multiple signatures can significantly delay deployments or decision-making. In fast-paced environments, especially global teams, this rigidity can hurt competitiveness. DORA highlights that relying heavily on centralized Change Approval Boards (CABs) often leads to bottlenecks. While CABs are intended to catch errors, members may be too far removed from the technical details to fully understand the impact of specific changes. This disconnect can result in both delays and poor decisions.

Another danger is treating all changes equally. Low-risk changes, such as minor configuration updates, often go through the same heavyweight approval process as high-risk system overhauls. According to DORA's research, this reduces efficiency and increases lead time. Instead of focusing attention on risky changes, teams become overwhelmed reviewing everything, which increases the likelihood of important issues slipping through.

There are also serious security and compliance risks when approval processes are poorly managed. Linford & Company notes that unauthorized changes, insufficient testing, lack of documentation, or failure to segregate duties can introduce vulnerabilities or malicious code into production. Emergency changes, if not properly approved, can bypass safeguards entirely.

Even worse, if version control and audit trails are not maintained, organizations may not be able to trace who made a change, creating accountability gaps.

Lastly, if an organization responds to production failures by adding more approval layers. DORA suggests that increasing process weight often increases lead times and batch sizes, creating a terrible cycle of instability. Instead of improving safety, it slows innovation and makes recovery harder. A better approach is investing in automation, better testing, and continuous improvement metrics such as change fail rate and lead time.

In conclusion, change approval processes are necessary, but they must be carefully designed. When too rigid or poorly implemented, they create delays, increase risk, and reduce accountability. The goal should not be to eliminate change risk through excessive approvals, but to make changes faster and safer through balanced, well-designed systems.

References

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